

XIAOCHUN (NORA) NIU

Email: xiaochun.niu@duke.edu ◇ Website: xiaochunniu.github.io ◇ Tel: (+1) 773-961-5347

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Duke University, The Fuqua School of Business
Postdoctoral Researcher in Decision Sciences
Advisor: Prof. Jiaming Xu

Durham, NC
July 2024–Present

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Northwestern University
Department of Industrial Engineering and Management Sciences
Advisors: Prof. Ermin Wei and Prof. Julia Gaudio

Evanston, IL
Sept. 2019–June 2024

B.S. Nanjing University
Department of Mathematics
National Elite Program (Honors Program)

Nanjing, China
Sept. 2015–June 2019

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Operations research, machine learning, network science, applied probability, high-dimensional statistics, optimization, and game theory.

PUBLICATIONS AND PREPRINTS

Journal Articles and Preprints

[†] Authors listed alphabetically.

- J1 “[High-Dimensional Procrustes Matching via Tree Counts](#).” Xiaochun Niu, Tselil Schramm, and Jiaming Xu.[†] Submitted to *Annals of Applied Probability*, 2026.
- J2 “[Optimality of Random Regular Graphs in Sparse Network Designs](#).” Weijia Li, Xiaochun Niu, Yehua Wei, and Jiaming Xu.[†] Major revision at *Operations Research*, 2026.
- Twenty-Seventh ACM Conference on Economics and Computation (EC 2026)
 - Oral presentation at INFORMS MSOM Annual Conference 2026
- J3 “[Learning with Shared Representations: Statistical Rates and Efficient Algorithms](#).” Xiaochun Niu, Lili Su, Jiaming Xu, and Pengkun Yang.[†] Accepted pending minor revisions at *Journal of Machine Learning Research*, 2026.
- Oral presentation at FL@FM–NeurIPS 2024
 - Oral presentation at INFORMS Workshop on Data Science 2026
- J4 “[Exact Label Recovery in Euclidean Random Graphs](#).” Julia Gaudio, Charlie Guan, Xiaochun Niu, and Ermin Wei.[†] *Annals of Applied Probability*, 2026.
- J5 “[DISH: A Distributed Hybrid Optimization Method Leveraging System Heterogeneity](#).” Xiaochun Niu and Ermin Wei. *IEEE Transactions on Signal Processing*, 2024.
- Extended abstract at Allerton Conference 2022
- J6 “[FedHybrid: A Hybrid Federated Optimization Method for Heterogeneous Clients](#).” Xiaochun Niu and Ermin Wei. *IEEE Transactions on Signal Processing*, 2023.

Conference Proceedings

- C1 “[Optimality of Random Regular Graphs for Sparse Network Designs.](#)” Weijia Li, Xiaochun Niu, Yehua Wei, and Jiaming Xu.[†] *ACM Conference on Economics and Computation (EC)*, 2026.
- C2 “[Incentive Analysis for Agent Participation in Federated Learning.](#)” Lihui Yi, Xiaochun Niu, and Ermin Wei. *IEEE Conference on Decision and Control (CDC)*, 2025.
- C3 “[Exact Community Recovery in the Geometric Stochastic Block Model.](#)” Julia Gaudio, Xiaochun Niu, and Ermin Wei.[†] *ACM-SIAM Symposium on Discrete Algorithms (SODA)*, 2024.
- **Nemhauser Prize for Best Student Paper**, 2024
- C4 “[Understanding Generalization of Federated Learning via Stability: Heterogeneity Matters.](#)” Zhenyu Sun, Xiaochun Niu, and Ermin Wei. *International Conference on Artificial Intelligence and Statistics (AISTATS)*, 2024.
- C5 “[DISH: A Distributed Hybrid Primal-Dual Optimization Framework to Utilize System Heterogeneity.](#)” Xiaochun Niu and Ermin Wei. *IEEE Conference on Decision and Control (CDC)*, 2022.

SELECTED HONORS AND AWARDS

- | | |
|---|------|
| • Rising Stars in Computational and Data Sciences, UT Austin | 2024 |
| • Nemhauser Prize for Best Student Paper, Northwestern University | 2024 |
| • SIAM Student Travel Award, SODA | 2024 |
| • Terminal Year Fellowship, Northwestern University | 2023 |
| • Arthur P. Hurter Award for Academic Excellence, Northwestern University | 2020 |
| • Walter P. Murphy Graduate Fellowship, Northwestern University | 2019 |
| • Excellent Graduate Award, Nanjing University | 2019 |
| • UCLA CSST Research Program Scholarship, University of California, Los Angeles | 2018 |
| • National Scholarship (<i>Top 2%</i>), Nanjing University | 2016 |

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Duke University

Instructor, EGRMGMT 580: Decision Models

Spring 2026

Northwestern University

Grader, IEMS 435: Stochastic Simulation

Spring 2022

Teaching Assistant, IEMS 344: Whole Brain Leadership

Fall 2021

SELECTED TALKS AND PRESENTATIONS

Optimality of Random Regular Graphs in Sparse Network Designs

- | | |
|---|-----------|
| • INFORMS Annual Meeting, San Francisco, CA | Nov. 2026 |
| • INFORMS MSOM Conference, Boston, MA | July 2026 |
| • INFORMS Annual Meeting, Atlanta, GA | Oct. 2025 |
| • Posters (2026): Cornell ORIE Young Researchers Workshop; NC Triangle Research Regional Exchange (Poster Award); INFORMS I-SIM Workshop (Honorable Mention); Stochastic Networks Conference. | |

Learning with Shared Representations: Statistical Rates and Efficient Algorithms

- INFORMS Workshop on Data Science, San Francisco, CA *Oct. 2026*
- INFORMS Applied Probability Society Conference, Atlanta, GA *June 2025*
- International Workshop on Federated Foundation Models (NeurIPS 2024), Vancouver *Dec. 2024*
- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Seattle, WA *Oct. 2024*
- Annual Allerton Conference on Communication, Control, and Computing (Allerton), UIUC *Sept. 2024*

Exact Community Recovery in the Geometric Stochastic Block Model

- IEMS-SIAM Student Seminar, Northwestern University *May 2024*
- Rising Stars in Computational and Data Sciences, UT Austin *April 2024*
- Institute for Data, Econometrics, Algorithms, and Learning (IDEAL) Special Program on Network and Inference, Toyota Technological Institute at Chicago (TTIC) *Jan. 2024*
- ACM-SIAM Symposium on Discrete Algorithms (SODA), Alexandria, VA *Jan. 2024*

DISH: A Distributed Hybrid Optimization Method Leveraging System Heterogeneity

- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Phoenix, AZ *Oct. 2023*
- INFORMS Annual Meeting, Indianapolis, IN *Oct. 2022*
- INFORMS Optimization Society Conference, Greenville, SC *Mar. 2022*

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Meta Platforms Menlo Park, CA

Research Scientist Intern, Social Impact Machine Learning Team *June 2022–Sept. 2022*

- Improved Facebook’s donation-specific newsfeed ranking algorithm by implementing new features and optimizing neural network architecture.

The Home Depot Atlanta, GA (remote)

Collaborative Data Project *Sept. 2022–Mar. 2023*

- Evaluated multi-armed bandit methods on dynamic ad placement datasets with frequent arm adjustments.

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE AND MENTORING

- Reviewer:
 - Journals: Operations Research, Annals of Statistics, Annals of Applied Probability, Journal of Machine Learning Research, Journal of Computational and Graphical Statistics, IEEE Transactions on Information Theory, IEEE Transactions on Automatic Control, IEEE Transactions on Signal Processing, IEEE Transactions on Signal and Information Processing over Networks
 - Conferences: SODA 2026, IEEE Conference on Decision and Control, Midwest Machine Learning Symposium, American Control Conference
- Session Organizer: IEEE CDC 2022 (Distributed Optimization and Learning for Networked Systems)
- Mentor: NCSSM Mentorship Program 2026, IDEAL Get Ready for Research Workshop 2023, INFORMS Mentorship Program 2023, Northwestern English Language Program 2022